

A P A R E N T I N G H A N D B O O K



Raising Wise Children Who Contribute to the World

Ten Principles for Nurturing Good Character

Namo Shakyamuni Buddha, Our Original Teacher

Drawn from the Vesak Address, 2026



A Note for Parents

Most of us are not born with transcendent character. We become good by being taught, by learning and training patiently over a long time, so that unwholesome impulses cannot pull us toward wrongdoing. Humanity still moves forward precisely because it knows how to educate: what is good is preserved and passed from one generation to the next.

Today we are fortunate to know the Dharma and to know how to cultivate ourselves. But what will become of the children who come after us if they are not properly taught? What will become of our families, our nation, and our world if the young grow up not through careful upbringing, but through the pull of peers and the endless scroll of short videos?

To bring a child into the world and raise them into a virtuous, useful person is to gather great merit; to bring a child into the world and fail to teach them is to carry a heavy debt. This handbook gathers ten principles to keep close as you raise your child. Read them slowly, return to them often, and let them ripen in daily life — in every word, every gesture, every quiet thought.

HOW TO USE THIS HANDBOOK

Each principle has three parts. **The teaching** explains why it matters. **In practice** offers small, concrete habits

to build day by day. **Try saying** gives words you can model and rehearse with your child.

Nothing here is taught once. These truths are repeated gently, day after day, until they soak into a child's heart and grow there into countless other virtues. You are not pressing; you are planting.



The Ten Principles

- 1 Teach Respect
- 2 Cultivate Compassion and the Desire to Help
- 3 Never Be Satisfied — Always Strive to Do Better
- 4 Practice Humility — Let Others Receive the Praise
- 5 Never Mock or Criticize with Contempt
- 6 Be Discerning about Peer Influence
- 7 Acknowledge Faults and Accept Correction
- 8 Cultivate Equanimity in the Face of Adversity
- 9 Teach Children to Meditate
- 10 Nurture Great Aspirations and a Sense of Service

PRINCIPLE

1

Teach Respect

THE TEACHING

The first virtue to teach a child is respect — for everyone around them, rich or poor; reverence for grandparents, parents, teachers, and elders; and above all, deep veneration for the Buddha and the awakened sages. This sense of respect is what forms a stable character that endures for life. Where children are taught the opposite — that adults must defer to them — their psychology is damaged from the very start, and they grow into adults who are defiant and a source of suffering for their family.

Children cannot yet grasp lofty philosophy; they need stories. Keep a store of tales about the Buddha and the Arahants and tell them again and again — the Buddha flying through the air, the Arahants subduing fearsome demons. Children love these dearly. Once a child loves hearing of the Buddha, teach them to bow and make offerings with sincerity before the Buddha image, at home or at the temple.

IN PRACTICE

- ◆ Speak to elders with proper courtesy; offer and receive objects with both hands.

- ◆ Bow the head slightly when passing before an elder; keep a respectful expression when speaking with those older.
- ◆ Speak kindly of respected people even in their absence — this earns merit; disparaging them harms one's own good fortune.
- ◆ Collect worthy stories — from books, the internet, and others — and tell them at bedtime instead of idle chatter.

*A child who honours those above
will, in time, be blessed to do much good.*

*A heart that holds the Buddha in reverence
will be quietly sheltered by the devas.*

PRINCIPLE

2

Cultivate Compassion and the Desire to Help

THE TEACHING

Many children are born already self-centered, thinking only of their own benefit. Left unredirected, such a child grabs food from siblings, competes for grades over peers, and as an adult fights for privileges over colleagues — causing discord wherever they appear, and even neglecting their own aging parents. Their life drifts toward loneliness and suffering.

So cultivate love for people and creatures, little by little: sharing a piece of cake with a friend, scattering a handful of rice for the birds, using New Year's gift money to help the poor. Speak of the altruistic spirit day after day, and the selfish tendency is gradually worn away while the generous heart grows.

IN PRACTICE

- ◆ Share food; feed birds and animals; give a portion of gift money to those in need.
- ◆ At family meals, tell true stories of selfless kindness — they nourish a child's soul.
- ◆ Stories to keep: the child who carried a disabled classmate to school for years; volunteers who repaired

a broken road; the man who planted trees until they became a forest; the family who moved their fence inward so the alley could be wider.

PRINCIPLE

3

Never Be Satisfied — Always Strive to Do Better

THE TEACHING

Teach children never to consider themselves finished, for with a little more effort one can always do better. When a child earns a high grade, finishes a chore, or does a good deed, praise them — that is simple fairness — but then gently ask whether they can think of a way to do it even better.

Do not press; simply pose the question and invite thought. Year after year, this quietly cures complacency, and the child learns to keep searching for a better way, in study and in life. This is the secret by which families nurture remarkable talent for their nation.

IN PRACTICE

- ◆ After every success, ask warmly: “Can you think of a way to do it even better?”
- ◆ Keep it an invitation, never a demand.

TRY SAYING

- “ Can you think of a way to clean the alley more thoroughly?*
- “ Can you think of a way to help old Mr. Ba get around more easily?*
- “ Can you think of a way to help the neighbourhood children study better?*
- “ Can you think of a way to speak English with a native accent?*

*What good is arrogance and complacency?
Beneath the sky there are always paths without end.*

Practice Humility — Let Others Receive the Praise

THE TEACHING

Teach children to be modest and never to boast. The world does need good examples to be inspired — but let our own good deeds be spoken of by others, while we speak of the good deeds of others. Each good story we tell is a brick in the building of the world.

Do good quietly, without display. When praised, respond graciously; inwardly, resolve to strive still harder so as not to disappoint those around you. In this way good fortune is preserved for a long time.

IN PRACTICE

- ◆ Redirect praise toward others; stay humbly in the background.
- ◆ Tell the good deeds of others freely; let your own be told by others.

TRY SAYING

- “ “I heard you won the maths award — is that right?” —
“Oh, Auntie, I was just lucky; my classmates are much
better than me.”
- “ “What a lovely child!” — “My siblings simply let me
have the good looks.”
- “ “Your competition essay was outstanding.” — “Teacher,
I only did as you taught me; my classmates let me go in
their place.”

*Let the praise be passed to others;
for myself I keep a humble smile.*

Never Mock or Criticize with Contempt

THE TEACHING

Teach children never to mock others. To deride with contempt instantly draws negative karma upon oneself — one later finds oneself afflicted with the very flaw one ridiculed. When we see a fault in someone, our heart should silently wish them free of it; and if the moment is right, we may offer gentle, compassionate guidance to help them overcome it.

Quiet, caring counsel that lifts a person past a shortcoming is a great merit — entirely different from spreading ridicule, tarnishing a reputation, and wounding someone. Teach children to stop criticism before it harms, and to turn critical remarks in a positive direction.

IN PRACTICE

- ◆ When others gossip or mock, gently steer the talk elsewhere; never join in.
- ◆ Look for a kind reading of every fault, and a way to help.

TRY SAYING

- “ “That child is so chubby” — “A little more muscle means more stored energy; that’s good.”*
- “ “That student is hopeless at studying” — “Perhaps no one is free to tutor them at home; let’s see if we can help.”*
- “ “Great voice, unfortunate face” — “A great voice is what matters; looks serve a different purpose.”*

*Harsh words tear the bonds of love;
kind counsel mends a gentle life.*

Be Discerning about Peer Influence

THE TEACHING

Teach children not to follow friends readily wherever they lead, for most wayward children are led astray by their peers. Among friends, formality falls away, so influence passes easily — and the boldest, most disruptive children often sway the rest. A child who refuses to follow may even risk being bullied.

So teach children to weigh a friend's character and choose good company. Know your child's world down to each friend; never be lax or indifferent. Pose many situations in advance and ask your child how they would answer, so they are ready when the moment comes.

IN PRACTICE

- ◆ Help your child judge friends by character, and choose accordingly.
- ◆ Stay close to your child's world; know each of their friends.
- ◆ Rehearse difficult scenarios together, again and again.

TRY SAYING

- “ If a friend asks you to skip class to play — what would you say to win them over?*
- “ If a friend speaks disrespectfully of a teacher — how would you reply?*
- “ If a friend urges you to live only for yourself and disobey your parents — how would you answer?*
- “ If a friend does wrong and tells you to keep it secret — how would you handle it?*

*Friends may bring you joy —
but do not let a friend bury your life.*

PRINCIPLE

7

Acknowledge Faults and Accept Correction

THE TEACHING

Teach children to admit mistakes, to apologize, and to sincerely reform — never to be obstinate or argumentative in defense of their errors. Everyone makes mistakes; the world improves, and each person improves, because we learn to admit our faults rather than stubbornly defend what is wrong.

Those who err and quickly acknowledge it, so as not to repeat it, spare themselves much future suffering. A child who learns this early will rarely make the same mistake again.

IN PRACTICE

- ◆ Welcome a child's apology warmly so honesty feels safe.
- ◆ Model admitting your own mistakes plainly and without drama.

TRY SAYING

“ Father, this morning I argued with my brother about watering the plants. I’m sorry, and I’ll go and apologize to him.”

“ Mother, last night I was sulky and disrespectful when my sister told me to study. I know that was wrong; I’ll apologize and obey.”

“ Teacher, yesterday I knew my classmate was wrongly accused but lacked the courage to defend him. I’m sorry; I won’t stand by again.”

*When wrong, admit it straight away;
and grow into a gentle soul for the land.*

Cultivate Equanimity in the Face of Adversity

THE TEACHING

Tell your child that life is full of things that run contrary to our wishes, and that they will meet many difficult, even malicious people. Let the heart harbour no hatred for anyone — yet stay careful not to trust too easily, especially those who speak with honeyed words.

Develop the inner strength not to grow angry or resentful when insulted. People offend one another easily; if we let every slight trouble us, no clarity is left for anything worthwhile. We guard our dignity calmly — those who hurl offensive words are usually in the wrong, so we need not be disturbed; and those who truly wish to help us improve will find a kind and discerning way to speak.

IN PRACTICE

- ◆ Keep self-respect without resentment; stay calm when insulted.
- ◆ Be wary of flattery; weigh honeyed words carefully.

Teach Children to Meditate

THE TEACHING

Children should learn to sit in meditation from a very early age, so that the brain develops in a stable and lasting way. And not only children — adults too should practice, to still the mind, to strengthen moral character, and to rise to a higher plane of being.

With a meditative mind, one can endure many adversities, hold to one's moral quality, and live a life filled with wisdom.

IN PRACTICE

- ◆ Begin with short, calm sitting; let it grow naturally with age.
- ◆ Practice alongside your child, so stillness is something you share.

Nurture Great Aspirations and a Sense of Service

THE TEACHING

Teach children to hold great dreams and a great sense of responsibility toward their country and the world. No one exists in isolation; anything that fails to interact with its surroundings destroys itself. The air we breathe, the water we drink, the food we eat — all are the wondrous coordination of the whole cosmos. We may be too small to do anything vast, but our souls must never be small: they must love all of heaven and earth, down to each petal and blade of grass.

Let a child's heart nurture the dream of serving and contributing — not merely of earning much money for themselves. Let service come first, and reward will follow. Any honest work that serves others is good: sweeping streets, engineering, waiting tables, leading a nation — all noble, if done in a spirit of service.

IN PRACTICE

- ◆ Praise the wish to serve above the wish to earn.
- ◆ Connect everyday gratitude — for air, water, food — to a love for all of life.

- ◆ Honour every honest kind of work as worthy when done to serve.

*How much our parents have poured forth —
we ask only to offer boundless service to this life.*



Closing Verse

*Walking upon lotus blossoms,
the Buddha has given the world a lamp of the spirit.
Far from clinging to ego and ignorance,
this planet is but a realm of peace.
We remember the Buddha's grace across a thousand
lifetimes;
we venerate the Buddha — a thousand words could
never say enough.*

**Namo the Great Heroic, the Great Powerful, the Great
Compassionate, the Great Merciful, Our Original
Teacher Shakyamuni Buddha.**